



The life cycle of international cooperation: Introduction to the special issue

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Published online: 11 July 2024
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Abstract

International organizations' lives often extend far beyond the moment of their initial contracting. How IOs do adapt to shifting circumstances in their member states global geopolitical changes, and even internal dynamics within the IO itself? This special issue on the life cycle of international cooperation explores the ebbs and flows of the IOs that underpin the international system. Firm theory, organizational sociology, and agency theory all have incorporated life cycles perspectives into the study of organizations, but IR has yet to fully harness these frameworks. A life cycles approach centers on, first, incorporating the IO itself as the core unit of analysis and, second, the dynamic processes within IOs — including life stages such as false starts, consolidation, inertia, growth, revitalization, death, and succession. Incorporating these dynamic processes into our understanding of IOs reminds us that historically, IOs have always experienced periods of both flourishing and faltering. Grasping the mechanisms that drive these changes is indispensable for a thorough understanding of the international system's vitality and resilience. Articles in this issue explore the durability of IOs in the face of crises; the measures that IOs deploy to legitimize their existence; the role of individual leaders' rhetoric in IO vitality; the tradeoffs that member states face between pulling the plug on an IO versus creating a new institution; the effect of member-state IO withdrawal on the international system overall; and the mass public's perceptions of such withdrawals.

Keywords International organization · International cooperation · Liberal order · Firms · Principal agent theory

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International organizations (IOs) today face challenges at a scale and scope that, to some, seem insurmountable. Countries that many assumed were democratizing now seem to be backsliding, despite predictions that their IO memberships served as credible commitments to political and economic reform (Baccini & Urpelainen, 2014; Pevehouse, 2002; Simmons, 1998), posing direct or indirect challenges to those IOs' legitimacy (Tallberg & Zürn, 2019). Economic and political tensions appear to be straining countries' ability and willingness to adhere to their multilateral commitments (Kucik & Peritz, 2021). IOs themselves look to be in ill health, as they struggle to enforce their mandates in the face of member-state pushback and backsliding (Meyerrose, 2020). At the same time, skepticism with internationalism seems on the rise (Copelovitch & Pevehouse, 2019), while institutions that pose challenges to the liberal order may be growing in stature (Debre, 2022). All of this could mean that the liberal order is straining against its limits (Börzel & Zürn, 2021).

However, claims about the rise and fall of international orders require close scrutiny of the IOs that underpin those orders in the first place, and whether one views these fluctuations as ordinary or extraordinary. The current state of global governance falls into perspective if one views international cooperation as subject to many fluctuations within their broader cycle of life.¹ In a life cycles view, the bargains behind the initial IO contract are but one moment within an IO's broader existence, and as IOs live their lives, they frequently experience variations in vitality as a response to internal and external pressures (Gray, 2018, 2020). Consider the fluctuations in the trade regime, both overall² and within the constituent organizations themselves, which have experienced death, stagnation, revitalization, and inertia. The vitality of those individual organizations are closely linked — both as cause and consequence — to the state of the cooperative liberal order more broadly.

This special issue explores the *life cycle of international organizations*, a framework that offers theoretical as well as empirical advances in the study of global governance. The articles in this issue center on the survival, decline, and adaptation of IOs. In some articles, IO life stages act as an outcome of interests (Eilstrup-Sangiovanni & Verdier, 2024; Haftel & Nadel, 2024). Other articles examine phenomena at the IO level that drive variation in IO vitality, such as legitimization activities (Schmidtke & Lenz, 2024), individual-level participation in IO debates (Baturó & Gray, 2024), and a hegemon's threat of withdrawal (Vabulas & von Borzyskowski, 2024). There is also an investigation of the consequences of IO vitality for the international system (Schmidt, 2024). The articles in this special issue examine both the

¹ Life stages initially had a broader meaning, stemming from the evolutionary perspective in biology, where a person's life moved sequentially and predictably through different stages (childhood, puberty, adulthood, old age), although these stages are more about development than about vitality or survival per se.

² The 20th century saw the short-lived Reciprocal Trade Agreements Act (Gowa and Hicks, 2012) to the failed International Trade Organization to the less formal General Agreements on Tariffs and Trade, which itself experienced ebbs and flows (Stiles, 1995) to the leap to the World Trade Organization, itself currently in crisis (Kucik et al., 2022). In contrast, scholars largely celebrated the formation of the WTO and the proliferation of regional and preferential trade agreements as signs of the vitality of the trade regime (Dür et al., 2014).

determinants of various stages of IO lives as well as how IOs themselves — and their member states — deal with issues of vitality, and how variation in IO vitality impacts the broader landscape of international cooperation. This provides a foundation for understanding how the institutions undergirding the international order can respond to their challenges, and the conditions under which they are likely to adapt, survive, wither, or die altogether.

IOs can experience several potential life stages, although not all of the stages are sequential, and not all IOs experience all of them. *False starts*, for failed negotiations or IOs that do not get off the ground, can even happen repeatedly for one cooperative effort (Kaya, 2016). Extant scholarship extensively documents the second stage, *births*, although ratification can delay the date in force (Haftel & Thompson, 2018). IOs may already in this period fall into *stagnation*, a state that can occur when IOs cannot get off the ground or when levels of inactivity turn them into zombies (Gray, 2018). Alternately, periods of high levels of activity can ensue, in which meetings and outputs occur; these can be periods of consolidation, *growth* and development — although it is important to stress that this is not synonymous with efficiency or performance, as growth can veer into mission creep and change can be suboptimal. *Revitalization* can occur in periods of stagnation as well as in productivity, or even following *IO death*. *Succession* or institutional replacement can occur after formal death — sometimes immediately and sometimes after several years (Cottrell, 2009). As with firms and agencies, however, the normative or substantive question of interest can determine a researcher's theory and measurement of each particular stage.

Well before their contracts are inked, international agreements can go through protracted and sometimes collapsed negotiations (Ye, 2023); their launch can be delayed or undermined in the legislature (Campello & Lemos, 2015; Haftel & Thompson, 2013; Kaya, 2016) or the introduction of legal reservations to the treaty (McKibben & Western, 2020), often from the very governments that signed the deal. Once launched, political turnover in member states can run IO commitments off track (Gray & Kucik, 2017; Grieco et al., 2009). Furthermore, IOs can fall into inertia (Genschel, 1997) and decline (Bunte et al., 2022; Debre & Dijkstra, 2021, 2023) or, conversely, survive early challenges only to fail subsequently (Hirschmann, 2023). In other words, IOs — like firms, agencies, and countless other organizations in both the public and private sphere³ — regularly confront existential challenges to which they must react in the interest of survival. These challenges often push IOs into different states of being at various points in their existence. A move toward international cooperation may drift into a zombie state even immediately after its birth, if member states delay ratification (as in many bilateral investment treaties (Haftel & Thompson, 2013) or if key members fail to ratify it altogether (as in the

³ Although this special issue focuses primarily on formal intergovernmental organizations, many other forms of global cooperation also experience ebbs and flows in their life cycle, such as international non-governmental organizations (Bush and Hadden, 2024), treaties (Fitzmaurice & Merkouris, 2020), informal organizations (Roger and Rowan, 2022), international norms and ideas (Finnemore & Sikkink, 1998; Stimmer, 2019), and diplomatic activities (Gray and Potter, 2020; Pouliot, 2015). Because the physical manifestations of their activities and the level at which they manifest differ so widely, they are not the primary focus of the matter of this SI — although many other scholars have discussed the variation in their vitality.

case of the postwar International Trade Organization (Kaya, 2016)). IOs may go from inertia to revitalization, as in the case of the post–World War II World Bank (Hosman, 2023) or, alternately, from inertia to death, as did the West European Union (Hofmann, 2009).

Acknowledging these life stages — and tracking them across IOs over time — reveals that the current crisis is hardly atypical in a historical context. The current strain on the liberal order is but one instance of the setbacks to which IOs frequently adapt — sometimes reacting to crisis, but often simply as a matter of course. And although states are almost always relevant to IOs, state-centric perspectives on IO vitality are incomplete. Pivots to, first, the IO itself as a unit of analysis and, second, the dynamic processes within IOs help define a life cycle framework.

This research takes seriously the primacy of IOs themselves in the study of global cooperation (March & Olsen, 1998; Ness & Brechin, 1988) and treats their vitality as a precondition for understanding international order. Although state-centered approaches usefully explain the bargains behind formal IO design and change (Lipsy, 2017), we cannot fully grasp the effectiveness of international cooperation unless we first take stock of the causes and consequences of the dynamic processes within IOs (Fioretos, 2017). This is particularly important because, despite issues of selection bias⁴ (which make it difficult to separate out the independent effects of IOs from the preferences of the member states that select into them; and false positives⁵ (which misattributes effects to IOs due to the preponderance of unobservable factors) in the empirical study of IOs, we know that IOs experience variation in vitality, regardless of design, members, issue area, or geography. Just as the trends of the 1990s — when an unprecedented number of countries formed and joined IOs after the end of the Cold War — led to scholarly exuberance about IOs, so too do we risk excessive disenchantment with IOs in the current era.

1 Variation in an IO's vitality over its life cycle

A life cycle perspective acknowledges, first, that IO vitality can rise and fall both within IOs and across the broader system (Abbott et al., 2016; Reinsberg, 2024) — and that such variation is neither exceptional nor linear. That is, all IOs go through various life stages, but the stages are neither inevitable nor necessarily sequential. This stands in contrast with many of the claims within the organizational life cycle literature, where a firm moves through successive stages over time. In contrast, IOs can ebb and flow through many different states in the course of their existence (Gray, 2020), and dynamic processes within IOs suggest that the good times as well as the bad can often prove ephemeral. For every heady beginning, member-state retrenchment and contestation can emerge later down the line (Chaudoin, 2014). The terrain of international cooperation is complex, and conditions both within and across IOs can shift dramatically even within a few years of the organization's founding (Hirschmann, 2023). Furthermore, “efficient” design cannot insulate IOs from

⁴ Downs et al. 1996; Vreeland, 2003; von Stein, 2005; Donno et al., 2015.

⁵ Chaudoin et al., 2018.

inertia and death: even prominent IOs such as the UN and its various agencies, the IMF, the World Bank, the WTO, and NATO, have experienced moments of decline and have even been on the brink of dissolution (McCalla, 1996). Acknowledging this reality offers a more sanguine picture of the history of international cooperation: IOs very frequently tackle hard problems and experience fluctuations in their vitality as they react to challenges.

We see these principles animated in the historical arc of international organizations. At the very inception of formal intergovernmental cooperation, the League of Nations hit trouble once the US Senate failed to ratify it in 1919 — despite the pivotal role that the US had played in its founding and designing (Lavelle, 2007). The International Trade Organization never got off the ground for the same reason (Kaya, 2016), and even the GATT, though successful in its initial round of trade liberalization, subsequently experienced a “lost decade” of failed negotiations despite multiple rounds of talks (Stiles, 1995). Indeed, in the immediate post–World War II era — often hailed as a watershed moment for international cooperation — the International Monetary Fund and the World Bank found their mission of post-war European reconstruction quickly eclipsed by the scale and scope of the Marshall Plan, hastily put into place by the US as distrust of the Soviets deepened. The United Nations hit challenges to its mandate once the former colonies joined in 1960 — only 14 years after the organization was put into place — and Secretary General Dag Hammarskjöld’s ambitious plans for a more interventionist UN went nowhere, after his tragic death alongside Cold War tensions tipped the organization into inertia. Even after the fall of the Berlin Wall, another period in which IOs seemed to be on the rise, many of the organizations and agreements that countries were rapidly forming, joining, and signing experienced drift (Gray, 2018). Although many of those organizations subsequently found their footing, notably, all of those examples can arise from periods that scholars consider to be fertile ground for durable interstate cooperation — in the shadow of damaging wars and at the closure of protracted eras of political tension. If such variation in vitality emerges even in those moments when interests seem aligned and commitments seem sincere, even more variation arises when IOs are formed in the presence of domestic or interstate conflict.

Different stages of life are, again, not necessarily synonymous with effectiveness or compliance; an organization’s life stage can be a necessary but insufficient condition for performance more broadly (Gutner & Thompson, 2010). Even though, for example, death and false starts may seem incompatible with good performance, an organization might die precisely because it has performed effectively and finished the job; or a series of false starts may lead to a better-designed agreement once it finally does emerge. At the same time, revitalization or rebirth through replacement also may not result in increased effectiveness, as Eilstrup and Verdier point out in this issue.

Second, IO life cycles, and their often-circular ebbs and flows more broadly, have consequences for the international system: when IOs decline, die, or change, this does not simply mean that efficient actors are just pruning off dying branches and moving to an optimal equilibrium of international cooperation. Rather, various stages in an IO’s cycle of life can represent changing realities, not

necessarily efficiency, and even IOs whose designs reflect protracted periods of bargaining may find themselves paralyzed by crisis. The actors who engage with IOs — from bureaucrats to world leaders — have their own motivations for engaging with IOs, and as such IO adaptations often reflect the motivations of those individual actors, rather than an efficient response to a “market failure” in cooperation.

Although studies of international cooperation recognized that all IOs did not experience equally good health (Strange, 1998; Shanks et al., 1996), attention tended to focus on outcomes and processes related to the member state: whether countries complied with their commitments to economic and political openness and, if they benefitted from those commitments, in terms of increased trade, investment, or FDI. At the same time, the rational design agenda put member-state bargains as central to explaining variation in formal IO design. Focusing on granular, temporal variation in the IO itself — decline, inertia, or death — has been less common, for several reasons. First, countries report — or researchers collect — their national-level political and economic information into easily accessible repositories; most IOs have no such mandate. Furthermore, the IOs that tend to have the best data are usually the larger, more prominent, often Western ones, even though such IOs only make up a small fraction of the total IO population over time. This makes the study of IO vitality in the face of these challenges particularly difficult — but it also means that due to these selection processes, our understanding of IOs tends to be informed by the larger and better-performing ones for which more data are available, creating problems for inference.

Although many scholars have studied formal change in IOs,⁶ the variation in IO vitality can arise from informal as well as formal practices (Roger, 2020; Vabulas & Snidal, 2013) and is best put into perspective by examining IOs over the entire course of their life. While states and their preferences are important to, and often drivers of, IO life stages, other actors and structures also have agency in IOs: bureaucracies, representatives, and delegates in particular. Nonetheless, for many of these stages — particularly birth and the negotiation of successor institutions, which require the formal agreement of member-state governments — state-centric approaches are especially useful⁵; in contrast, stages such as inertia and overall survival require focus on IOs (Haftel & Nadel, 2024) or on the individuals within IOs (Baturó & Gray, 2024). At the same time, IR applications of organizational ecology (Abbott et al., 2016; Keohane & Morse, 2014) acknowledge the broader ecosystem in which IOs operate, but tend to put member state choices as the primary drivers. We may assume that the organizations that states design — to say nothing of the states themselves — simply behave in rational, or boundedly rational, ways, and that the same processes of power- and interest-based bargaining remain at play throughout the course of an IO's existence. But it is unclear whether the same frameworks that drive a state to join an IO also determine its functioning, or dysfunction, going

⁶ IR scholars examine formal change in rules and procedures of IOs (Jupille et al., 2013; Lipsky, 2015), while the historical institutionalist literature (Fioretos et al. 2016; Mahoney and Thelen, 2010; Thelen, 2009) provides insight to international organizations (Fioretos, 2017; St John, 2018; Fioretos, 2019). Within the IR literature more broadly, the survival and termination on alliance termination offers parallels (Walt, 1997).

forward (Barnett & Finnemore, 1999). Other frameworks — such as organizational culture, theories of bureaucracy, and principal agent models — should also be taken into account in determining an IO's cycle of life.

In sum, a life cycles approach expands our understanding of international cooperation temporally (because lives are dynamic processes, and because looking at false starts and failures often require a long view), geographically (in cross-region comparison, because many similarly structured IOs face different fates), and structurally (in looking at IO bureaucracies and durations themselves and not just the interests, capabilities, and preferences of their member states). This means bringing history and time into the study of IOs; comparing institutions in the global South as well as the developed world; and taking seriously the individuals within the IOs — meaning staff, negotiators, advisers, and delegates — alongside member-state governments.

2 Life cycle theory across disciplines, and applications to IOs

Scholarship across economics, sociology, public administration, management, and anthropology has used the life cycle concept to study myriad institutions, including firms, agencies, cultural units, and private as well as nonprofit organizations. Although these varied research agendas carry useful lessons for the study of international cooperation, they also have some limits in their applicability, with political agencies as perhaps the most useful comparison (Lewis, 2002).

The preponderance of economic models in IR make it somewhat surprising that a life cycles approach has been so long in coming to the study of international cooperation.⁷ But approaches in firm studies and industrial organization take life cycles as a given and necessary reality within a competitive context (Agarwal & Gort, 2002; Brüderl et al., 1992). Firm perspectives emphasize that changing market conditions, customer demands, and technological advancements mean that firms must almost constantly adapt to remain profitable and avoid failure (Christensen, 1997; Mansfield, 1963), particularly when they are in competitive markets (Porter, 1985). Such approaches contextualize an organization's survival as hinging on a fast-changing environment with many competing pressures — an utterly different backdrop than an approach that considers IOs as operating in a relatively stable international system, as seems to be the presumption of many analyses of the liberal order.

Given the mercurial conditions in which they must operate, and the degree to which exogenous conditions shape firm behavior (Meyer & Rowan, 1977), firms as organizations inevitably go through cycles of life, and those that cannot adapt will fail. But even that adaptation — often conceptualized in these frameworks as the introduction of new products or services — is often followed by periods

⁷ See Keohane (1984), where Chapter 6 looks at political market failures and the Coase theorem. Economic models of bargaining featured prominently IR approaches to cooperation; see Krasner (1991); Morrow (1994); Abbott and Snidal (1998); Fearon (1998); Koremenos et al. (2001) for foundational contributions. However, the focus on symmetry in bargaining and the resultant contract obscure the fate of the institution, once formed. Although Waltz (1979) compared state survival to firm survival, he does not incorporate life stages in his framework.

of consolidation (Tushman & O'Reilly, 1996; Williamson, 1965) before a firm is forced to innovate once more. Even a firm that successfully innovates under one set of conditions may fail when confronted with a different challenge.⁸ Extensive literature, for example, investigates the role of systemic factors such as low interest rates, weak banks, and bankruptcy laws on the preponderance of “zombie” firms — defined as unprofitable firms with low stock market valuation — in a given setting (Storz et al., 2017; Banerjee and Hofmann, 2018; Andrews and Petroulakis, 2019).

And yet IOs differ from firms in several important ways.⁹ Most IOs do not depend on profitable outputs in to survive (Dunne et al., 1988; Klepper and Simons, 2000).¹⁰ Furthermore, depending on their mandate, they do not all face pressures to grow and expand to increase their profit margin (Audretsch, 1995); think of technical organizations that regulate fairly conscribed issue areas such as river navigation or commodity prices. Additionally, they do not necessarily enjoy economies of scale, nor do they necessarily have a need to seek new markets (Caves, 1998); although sometimes change and expansion can be efficient (Haftel & Hofmann, 2017), indeed, expansion into new domains often results in mission creep, and the transposition of particular models in different geographic and political contexts often results in an implementation gap (Gray, 2014; Lenz, 2012). Although firm life cycle theory looks at outputs that include a broad range of organizational activities and structure, it tends to assume that life stages are sequential and irreversible — and yet we see IOs that move between inertia and rebirth and back again.¹¹ This is partially due to the relative longevity of IOs compared with firms, not least because the bureaucracies of IOs often become entrenched (Strange, 1998). Around half of all businesses fail within one and a half years, and the median age of all firms is only seven years. In contrast, although newer IOs have a higher probability of dying (Debre & Dijkstra, 2021), death itself is relatively rare in some subsets of IOs¹² but across two centuries of global governance occurs around 30 percent of the time (Eilstrup-Sangiovanni, 2021). Furthermore, in terms of financing, IOs experience perhaps the opposite trajectory of firms: IOs start out with funding commensurate with their goals but often fall into deficits, given budget arrears and overextensions (Engel and Mattheis, 2019), while firms usually lose money in their initial years before turning profits, which perhaps contributes to the liability of newness in firm life cycles (Brüderl & Schussler, 1990). Finally and relatedly, innovation plays an outsized role in both firm and product life cycles: market shares depend on novelty, which means that firm survival hinges on generating — or at least creating the perception of — product

⁸ Notably, this literature also acknowledges that selection and endogeneity are a problem for inference: see Thompson (2005).

⁹ At the same time, firms themselves hardly operate on the basis of market forces alone (Jensen, 2000; Levinthal & March, 1981), although a full discussion is beyond the scope of this paper.

¹⁰ International financial institutions and development banks are one exception to this; they finance themselves at least in part through the interest on their loans (Vreeland, 2003).

¹¹ Many IOs in the global South, for example, disbanded only to revitalize decades later — such as the East African Community, which died in 1977 and reformed in 1997, as did the Arab Maghreb Union, which fell into dormancy in 1998 despite attempts at revitalization.

¹² See Gray (2018) on economic IOs, where death is around 12 percent of the sample. That said, because many IOs emerged only at the end of the Cold War, the sample for newer IOs is to some extent censored.

innovation. International organizations, however, have a strong status quo bias and indeed often struggle to actualize the very details of their founding bargain, given systemic as well as member-state shifts.

This points to a need to study IO life cycles as organizations operating largely outside of market forces, in which agency theory and the study of bureaucracy take central roles.¹³ As intergovernmental structures, IOs act as bureaucracies (DiMaggio & Powell, 1983; Niskanen, 1971; Weber, 1922). Like domestic agencies and public administrations, they can face pathologies in balancing the interests of competing factions (March & Simon, 1958; Moe, 1984). They walk a similar line between the autonomy necessary for them to fulfill their mandates, versus accountability for their processes, as illustrated in principal-agent models (Johnson, 2014; Pollack, 1997; Vaubel, 2006); the distant nature of IO secretariats also can make monitoring difficult (Hawkins et al., 2006; Honig, 2018). International public administrations operate in conditions similar to the complex and multifaceted environment of competitive business markets, but with the stickiness and status-quo bias of agencies (Knill & Bauer, 2007). Although firms can also operate through processes of bounded rationality and principal-agent dynamics, agencies are also subject to interest group mobilization and network dynamics (Balla & Gormley, 2017).

Furthermore, the agents involved in IOs produce outputs that can be difficult to judge using market standards. This means that rather than being motivated by performance, they tend to be incentivized by, as Downs (1967, page 35) put it, a “complex set of goals including the following elements: power, income, prestige, security, convenience, loyalty (to an idea, an institution, or the nation), pride in excellent work, and desire to serve the public interest.” In the absence of clearly defined outputs, agents must cultivate personal reputations (Carpenter & Krause, 2012) that can help them build coalitions and gain control of their policy domains (Carpenter, 2000). This allows agents to maneuver within the existing rules and confines of their mandates (Potter, 2019).¹⁴

These are strikingly different units of analysis and incentive structures than what much of the research on IOs of the past decades considers. The primacy of state interests and the nature of the cooperative problem led to a focus on international bargains, with the state (or the state-IO) as the unit of analysis and the IO itself defined by static features of the agreement at a fixed point (its onset, or a subsequent formal revision). While the literature on international public administration delineates the particularities of global agencies (Fleischer & Reiners, 2021; Thorvaldsdottir et al., 2021), the cycle of life has yet to be fully incorporated as an important theoretical framework.

A life cycles approach, then, necessitates two pivots. The first is continuing to move away from the state as the unit of analysis, as has been long promoted by

¹³ See Brierley et al. (2023) for an excellent recent overview of the literature on bureaucracies in US politics. Seminal works include Blau and Scott (1962), which developed frameworks for cross-organizational comparison; Niskanen (1968) on the political environment in which bureaucrats operate; Potter and Shipan (2019) on nonmarket decisionmaking in bureaucratic rulemaking.

¹⁴ Similarly, in the management literature (Suchman, 1995), organizations build, maintain and defend legitimacy; while at all those stages organizations exhibit vitality, the challenges and appropriate responses differ at each stage.

constructivist frameworks (Finnemore, 1996; Finnemore & Sikkink, 2001) to the IO itself (as Haftel and Nadel, and Schmidtke and Lenz, do in this issue), to the individuals operating within that IO (Gray and Baturo, in this issue), to the broader system in which those IOs operate (Schmidt, and Vabulas and von Borzyskowski in this issue).¹⁵ The second pivot focuses on temporal processes *within* a given IO (Hanrieder, 2015), and by extension on the broader history of IOs beyond just the period after the fall of the Berlin Wall. The markers of formal change within an IO — such as an amendment to the agreement or a change in its membership structure — are far less frequent than the gradual shifts and de facto daily practices that can mark the different stages of a life cycle.

Studying an organization's life cycle also places IOs in a broader comparative and systemic context. If we seek to explain organizational life stages, we must consider why IOs with similar attributes experience different fates; this requires comparing IOs in the global North as well as the global South, and considering the trajectories of IOs beyond the ones that are the easiest to study. Furthermore, IOs interact with the broader population of other IOs in the system; this draws literature on organizational ecology (Abbott et al., 2016; Gehring & Faude, 2014), networks within IOs (Greenhill & Lupu, 2017), and regime complexity in IR (Henning & Pratt, 2024).¹⁶ Life cycles approaches can intersect with social evolutionary models of organizations (Aldrich, 1979), which assume that some organizations will select into survival while others fall out of the sample (Campbell, 1965).

The precise markers to identify various life stages differ even in the foundational life cycles literature. Several distinct models have been postulated, ranging from three to ten stages (Lester et al., 2003). In studies of the firm, the phases follow some arc including startup, growth, maturity, decline, renewal (five); growth, maturity, and decline (three); alternately innovation, growth, and decline, followed by renewal (four). For Downs (1967), government bureaus experience specific dynamics in each life stage: for example, a struggle for autonomy may take place before or immediately following an agency's birth; then establishing of legitimacy; then expansion, and then to formalization and control. The IO life cycle stages described above — false starts, births, stagnation, change, death, and succession — can vary depending on the issue area that the IO covers, and particular markers for those stages may vary depending on researchers' theoretical interest, just as in the life cycles literatures across disciplines.¹⁷ There are limits to the metaphor: unlike in organic life cycles, not every IO experiences all those stages, nor necessarily in exact sequence. Nonetheless, the determinants and consequences of variation in IO vitality across life stages are an important component of international order.

¹⁵ In this issue, Eilstrup and Verdier use state-centric perspectives on IO bargains around death and replacement.

¹⁶ The same holds true for NGOs; Bush and Hadden (2024) show that INGOs in the US make choices about their founding, mission scope, and geographic location based on the existing population of other NGOs.

¹⁷ For example, Debre and Dijkstra (2023) use a definition of decline that centers on the population and on the frequency of its mentions at the UN, while others focus on IO outputs to define their vitality; see Tallberg et al. (2016); Gray (2018).

3 Units of analysis in IO stages

The study of organizational life cycles almost by definition moves the unit of analysis away from the principal (in this case, the member state) and onto the agent (in this case, the organization) (Pollack, 1997). That said, research in organizational life cycles across disciplines grapples with some disagreement over several issues. First, what do they define as an organization? Second, given any particular definition, who are the relevant actors within and outside the IO? How do variations in IO life stages impact the overall system of international cooperation?

First, the parameters of what counts as an organization are particularly important, as they define the subsequent empirical domain, as well as suggesting varying definitions of output that would be consistent with vitality. Organizational life cycle metaphors across disciplines and subfields offer their own scope conditions. In the pioneering use of a life cycle metaphor in the study of institutions, Marshall (1890) compared firms to trees in a forest, with the idea that they compete for scarce resources (in this metaphor, sunlight). The idea of organizational life cycles proliferated in economics and in management studies, with firms as the unit of analysis. Sociologists broadened the lens to public institutions such as schools (Hannan & Freeman, 1977). In American politics, scholars also examined the creation and termination of individual agencies at the domestic level (Heclo, 1977; Lewis, 2002).¹⁸ A substantial literature in international public administration applies organizational theories to IOs (Bauer et al., 2017; Fleischer & Reiners, 2021; Knill & Steinebach, 2022). This line of research emphasizes that IPAs represent actors distinct from their member states, with an independent influence on international policy, given the degree of autonomy and resources that they possess (Knill et al., 2022). Such a view focuses on the IO itself, and its attributes, including the composition of its staff and the resources that it possesses or lacks (Graham, 2017). Constructivist frameworks have long emphasized the importance of individuals and cultures within IOs (Barnett & Finnemore, 2004; Barnett & Solingen, 2007; Chwieroth, 2009; Finnemore, 1996). At the same time, many international organizations can co-exist with informal institutions (Roger, 2020; Roger & Rowan, 2022) and, at different stages of their life cycle, such informality may prevail in alternate but linked venues (Lugg, 2024).

The choice of the unit of analysis conditions the study of the relevant actors, as different types of agents inhabit different types of organizations. For example, firm life cycle theories place heavy emphasis on leadership in organizations, with managers and executives being central to the navigation between life stages (Hall & Woods, 2018). For studies of government agencies, focus is given to the staff themselves and the nature of their appointment — on either a merit or political basis, with the latter

¹⁸ The importance of endogenous design in these literatures is debated. Indeed, bargaining models assume that preferences and group characteristics (including the number of actors as well as their heterogeneity in terms of both capabilities and preferences) determine the structure of institutional choice, and that the institution one observes is the optimal one for the cooperation problem and the relevant actors. In studies of US agencies, different factions compete over the agency's role and responsibilities, with every group lobbying for its own interests. The resulting compromises can make the resulting agency explicitly — and even intentionally — dysfunctional (Moe, 1989). But see, for example, Boin et al. (2010); in their study of FDR's New Deal organizations design factors do matter, but their effects change over time.

category subject to built-in obsolescence in the presence of turnover in the office of the executive as well as the legislature. For treaties, which also experience exits (Huikuri, 2023) and decline (Barnum & Lo, 2020) despite not having secretariats or staff, differing definitions of vitality depend on the issue area and the international law surrounding them; although all treaties should be ratified and entered into force, trade agreements would have different vitality benchmarks than would investment agreements,¹⁹ and security treaties often hinge on limiting outputs such as the proliferation of arms or the development of nuclear weapons (Coe & Vaynman, 2020).

In this special issue's articles, the particular life stages under study as well as the research question itself can suggest different units of analysis. In looking at legitimacy dynamics, Lenz and Schmidtke focus on how IOs grapple with challenges, whereas Vabulas and von Borzyskowski look at changes in legitimacy through the eyes of the mass public, in response to a member state exiting an IO. In terms of variation in legitimacy and politicization within subagencies of an IO, Baturu and Gray examine the varying rhetoric of individual delegates that inhabit the public forum for debate. State-centered approaches are relevant to formal changes in IO structure; Eilstrup-Sangiovanni and Verdier, explain IO change in the standard rationalist and state-centric way without any focus on IO agency — although it is probable that decisionmakers at the IO level have some incentive in ensuring their own survival, if only so that they can keep their jobs. Finally, in looking at survival dynamics, Haf-tel and Nadel focus on the IO's overall duration in relation to crises, whereas in the question of broader impact Schmidt moves the focus to the system level.

4 Dynamic processes in IO life cycles

Many scholars bring organizational theory in the study of IOs; seminally, March and Olsen, (1998), Ness and Brechin, (1988) called for greater incorporation of the study of organizations in international cooperation, a call taken up by, among others Barnett and Finnemore, 1999, 2004 and Nielson and Tierney 2003.²⁰ However, a life cycles approach — although in many other disciplines a logical extension of the study of organizations — has yet to be articulated in political science, largely due to two primary constraints, one theoretical and the second empirical. First, the theoretical lenses of rational design and open-economy politics placed heavy emphasis on state interests as the primary drivers of international cooperation. The primacy of economic bargaining models meant that, by extension, the preferences and the leverage of countries negotiating the agreement drew focus.

The prominence of rational bargaining frameworks had implications for the empirical domain of IO study. Such models also implied that countries' preferences over approaching a particular cooperation problem — and who would pay the

¹⁹ See Gray and Slapin (2012); Gray (2014), who evaluate trade agreements based on expert assessments of trade created as a function of firm behavior, whereas investment agreements' formal legal status and legal remedies underscore their vitality.

²⁰ Other prominent examples include Weaver, 2008; Johnson, 2014; Heldt, 2017 in their incorporation of principal agent dynamics; see also Pouillot and Therien, 2023.

costs and bear the consequences of cooperation — girded the agreement itself. This meant that either a binary measure of the organization itself, or else easily coded aspects of the contract — such as its level of legalization (McCall Smith, 2000), depth (Dür et al., 2014), authority (Hooghe & Marks, 2020; Hooghe et al., 2016; Zürn, 2012, 2020), flexibility (Kucik & Reinhardt, 2008), or breadth of issues covered (Haftel, 2013; Kelemen et al., 2014) — served as a reflection of the potential gain from agreement relative to the costs of institutional setup. In such frameworks, if the gains were small, an agreement would not be formed, or would fall apart once formed.²¹ Such assumptions proved sufficient given the dominant research methodologies following the Cold War — namely, time-series cross-section analyses motivated by formal models in which states were the primary actors.²² A binary indicator of IO existence meant that hundreds of IOs could be accounted for using the same metric; a focus on the gains of cooperation at the state level meant that researchers could rely on readily available economic and political statistics.

But a life cycle approach requires two shifts away from the state-year, or IO-year level. The first is to investigate change over time. The importance of *temporal* processes in IOs is critical to a life-cycles perspective. Time is particularly important because it lays bare the way that institutions — and actors within those institutions — can maneuver around whatever formal design states concocted. The periods of activity between formal treaty revisions often see informal shifts within IOs as actors navigate existing rules, and these changes only becomes apparent through scrutinizing how IOs work over time (Buzas & Graham, 2020). Time elucidates how design features play out in real life, but in the shadow of formal changes, as has been acknowledged in agency studies of delegation; Boin et al. (2010) argue that feedback effects in the way that staff and other actors inhabit IO designs mean that agency survival is not simply a function of initial institutional design.²² Wilks and Bartle (2002) also note that in competition agencies, delegations mean that agents develop their own preferences, influence, and legitimacy, such that they are no longer dependent on politicians; they describe this as an unanticipated and even unintended consequences of delegation. Organizational life cycle theory more broadly emphasizes that organizations evolve independently from their size and chronological age; rather than years in existence, decreased flexibility and adaptability are the appropriate markers of decline (Adizes, 1979; Mosca et al., 2021). Second, a life cycles approach necessarily requires close scrutiny of the inner workings of IOs, and making decisions about what “counts” in the development of an IO’s trajectory. This often means shifting the unit of analysis away from the country level, and away from a binary coding of the IO itself that remains unchanged throughout time. Instead, IO scholarship on vitality needs to look within the IO itself to its agencies and sub-agencies; at its leadership as well as its broader staff; at its reports and outputs; at informal processes alongside formal changes; and at the failed initiatives within IOs as well as the successful ones.

²¹ As Koremenos, (2013, 338) put it, “Cooperation is not always worth it. Theories of agreement design make sense at the stage at which cooperation is thought to be worth it.”

²² But see Johns (2007); Fang (2008).

This can result in varying judgments in defining stages in an IO's cycle of life. Design, formation, and ratification are relatively easy to observe and uncontroversial to record. However, scholars may have reasonable differences in opinion on the thresholds and cutpoints for vitality that constitute different stages of life. How long do IOs have to stay inert to count as dead? How fundamentally do IOs have to change in order to count as a new organization, versus a successor, versus a continuation of the previous one? Informal practices that play a key role in determining life stages only become apparent through examining IOs over their entire history, and researchers may come to different decisions about operationalizing different stages in the cycle of life.

5 Articles in the special issue

Many scholars assume that domestic crises herald the end of cooperation. IO skeptics might argue that international cooperation is a luxury for most countries, and that when times are tough, countries will reallocate their attentions to domestic matters. Such inattention could contribute to inertia in IOs, ultimately leading to their death — indeed, many IOs have died or gone inert in the face of violent conflict (such as the Mano River Union's long paralysis in the face of civil conflicts, or the Central American Common Market's inertia following the 1979 "soccer war" between El Salvador and Honduras). Haftel and Nadel, however, argue and show that crises are often a chance for an IO to show its quality and for member states to appreciate the benefits that IOs can bring. Although many scholars assume that crises lead to the rise of populist leaders who then renege on their international commitments, Haftel and Nadel argue that, in fact, economic hard times underscore the ability of IOs to tackle the root causes of crises and to mitigate their most pernicious effects. Not only do economic crises not result in IO death, but they can even prolong an IO's lifespan. Haftel and Nadel further argue that IOs with an economic mandate especially enjoy the support of crisis-ridden member states. They also expect currency crises to have greater cross-border repercussions, compared to banking and sovereign debt crises, due to their greater potential for cross-border contagion. This, in turn, will result in greater need for a coordinated response through IOs. Their findings imply that the benefits of IOs can come into focus during economic crises, and that IOs that can help states withstand economic shocks may prove particularly long-lasting, and perhaps even more vital (Haftel, 2020).

Even when IOs do fold, death is not always the end. Eilstrup and Verdier examine the relationship between IO death and institutional replacement. Departing from arguments that status quo pressures and bounded rationality will nudge states toward sticking with the existing institution (Jupille et al., 2013), Eilstrup and Verdier show an important incentive to form a new IO altogether. By reconfiguring the institution anew, states can bypass members who might have acted as veto players in the IO's activities and scope. As such, they argue that simply reforming an existing IO may just perpetuate the problems that led to a standstill in the first place. The authors use a game-theoretic model to illustrate the incentive structures faced by the relevant actors, and the strategic calculations that those actors make in their struggles

to make cooperation possible. They thus highlight the importance of perceptions of performance in IO life cycles as well as the difficulty of inferring effectiveness from any one of an IO's life stages on its own. Death and replacement are not necessarily signs of failure; rather, they can be rational responses to gridlock in an existing IO. Furthermore, killing off and reconstituting an IO may be the best chance of achieving meaningful cooperation. Although this article, in the tradition of rational design, focuses primarily on the incentives and strategies of member states — not of IO agents themselves — it nonetheless highlights important patterns in the types of bargains that countries consider.

A single IO can contain many different and largely autonomous branches, each of which serve a different function. Furthermore, individuals play different roles within different arms in an IO. In the case of the UN, for example, the Security Council plays a different function than do the UN's myriad agencies, some of which have more vitality than others at different points. In this context, Baturo and Gray (2024) examine the increased tendency of world leaders to use the UNGA as a pulpit. The UNGA has long been in the throes of various revitalization initiatives; these coincided with what seems to have been a shift in leader attendance at the assembly. Although historically, leaders infrequently spoke at the UN, around the year 2000, the norm shifted, and heads of state now take their country's speaking slot around half of the time. But do their appearances help move along the agenda of international cooperation and enhance the UNGA's vitality? Two possibilities present themselves: either heads of state appear at IOs because their country prioritizes international cooperation, and as such their presence could indicate the salience of the IO's agenda to their own nation. Alternately, leaders could appear for their own motivations, whether for personal prestige or as a result of the constraints or mandates of their own political situation at home (Baturo & Gray, 2023). Speech — itself a relevant output in the vitality of the UNGA — varies between leaders and those of other delegates. Consistent with theories of leader communication (Dewan & Myatt, 2008), that rather than adapt their language to be more congruent with their environment (Bayram & Ta, 2019; Lindsey, 2017), leaders instead use more general language and talk about items distant from the session's agenda. These findings suggest that leaders may politicize IOs, rather than enhance them through their presence.

The vitality of IOs' general assemblies also bridges with the strategies that IOs undertake to legitimate their own existence (Bexell et al., 2022; Gronau & Schmidtke, 2016). This shifts the presumption of agency from member states and delegates, and assumes instead that IO staff and leadership can play an active role in their organization's survival and vitality. Indeed, as bureaucracy scholarship acknowledges, reputations and legitimacy allow agencies to exercise and even increase their autonomy (Carpenter, 2001). For IOs, the act of legitimation can serve as an attempt to revitalize or to ensure its autonomous functioning. Schmidtke and Lenz investigate IOs' strategies of legitimation in reference to an IO's cycle of life. They show that IO legitimation is not reactive, but rather proactive; that is, IOs often attempt to get ahead of the narrative when they expand their authority. Taking the unit of analysis down to the level of the agent, Schmidtke and Lenz show that acts of legitimation go hand in hand with an increase in authority, and that — mindful of the potential political backlash — IOs take

steps to improve their reputations in advance. This brings in canonical arguments about bureaucratic authority and reputations at the international level, while also extending an important argument in the study of bureaucracies against a backdrop of *anticipated* IO decline and pushback. Their findings also elucidate the slippery nature of measurement of IO life stages; even if we see no contestation emerge in an IO's lifespan, it could be due to active, behind-the-scenes management on the part of the IO.

How do variations in IO life stages impact the overall system of international cooperation? In this issue, Schmidt addresses the systemic consequences of IO vitality by examining how treaty withdrawal impacts the broader system of international law. While a single state leaving an IO has been linked to IO decline and death (Vabulas and von Borzyskowski, 2021), Schmidt argues treaty withdrawal has both a direct and an indirect effect on the negotiation of new multilateral treaties. On the one hand, treaty withdrawal has a direct effect on the treaty regime where it occurs by prompting a crisis that leads remaining states to negotiate new agreements so that the regime may adapt and survive. On the other hand, withdrawal sours diplomatic relations between treaty members and the withdrawing state, inhibiting their ability to negotiate new agreements successfully in other areas of cooperation. Consequently, withdrawal can have two opposing effects on the life stages of international institutions: it can both prompt periods of revitalization and increase the risk of false starts in the form of failed negotiations. Schmidt tests this argument using an original panel of treaty regimes drawn from comprehensive UN data. He finds statistical support for both the direct and indirect effects of withdrawal. However, his analysis indicates that withdrawal's negative indirect effect far exceeds its positive direct effect — there would have been nearly one-third more multilateral treaties created from 1945 through 2018 had there not been any withdrawals during this period.

Beyond the overall system effects, what are the repercussions of withdrawal on the ground? Vabulas and von Borzyskowski examine the domestic politics of IO withdrawal. They argue that politicians (with a focus on the US case) announce IO withdrawal on the campaign trail to rally domestic electoral support. This is because Americans' support for multilateralism divides along party lines, and discussing IO withdrawal can activate those preferences. Moreover, when politicians frame an IO withdrawal as benefiting US national interests, voters are more likely to favor IO withdrawal. These expectations are tested with data from four US survey experiments during the 2017–2021 Trump administration and the authors find empirical support for these arguments. The results show that IO withdrawal (and how it is framed) affects voters' choice of candidates and support of policies meaning that different stages of the IO life cycle may affect (and be affected by) domestic politics. Their paper also shows that even when IOs are going through challenging stages of their life cycles, a large proportion of the public may still value remaining in the IO, emphasizing the importance of examining the long view of IOs. The authors reason that sunk cost fallacies, status quo bias, and loss aversion may pose friction points that prevent the public from capriciously supporting withdrawal from stagnating IOs.

6 Conclusion

This special issue seeks to show that IOs always operate within different stages within an overall life cycle — a concept that is used extensively in economics, management, and organizational sociology but has yet to be systematically studied in the context of international cooperation. Any IO that attempts to tackle a serious cooperation problem will face challenges, and its vitality will likely shift in the face of those challenges. Assuming that IOs will simply operate without confronting setbacks — and, indeed, without bending and even reshaping to accommodate some of those strains — fundamentally misreads the actual trajectories of international cooperation, which forever travel through various stages of life.

The application of firm and organizational life-cycle theory to the study of international organizations provides a framework for understanding the developmental trajectories and adaptive behaviors of IOs on the global stage. The articles in this special issue show the implications of IOs moving through not just inception but also growth, maturity, and decline phases, shedding light on the unique challenges and opportunities encountered at each stage. IOs not only establish their missions but also evolve their structures and respond to external pressures; these life-cycle dynamics matter for the effectiveness, relevance, and sustainability of international organizations in an ever-changing global landscape.

Viewing international cooperation through a life-cycle lens reveals a more dynamic, porous international order. Many empirical studies focus implicitly on the formation of international agreements, assuming that if countries form an IO, they want it to succeed. This perspective suggests that once IOs are formed, they will naturally progress upward, and any changes signify successful bargains. But some kinds of IO changes are better understood either as a form of self-destruction, or as an attempt to revitalize when failure seems imminent. Contrary to common perceptions, IO dissolution may not always be a failure of cooperation. Sometimes IOs conclude their missions and dissolve; in that instance IO death can be a positive rather than a negative development. Conversely, IOs that find ways to survive in the midst of crises may outlive their mandate and persist despite inefficiency.

Such a view sheds new light on an empirical puzzle in the study of international cooperation. International institutions are generally assumed to be “sticky” — that is, they are thought to remain largely unchanged once they form. But in fact, IOs can change quite a bit, and those changes vary in scope and in degree. International organizations’ dynamism occurs not only in the formal revisions and renegotiations on which scholars have previously focused, but also in their daily operations. IOs’ life stages reveal new angles on the complexities of international cooperation. Their vitality varies over time, as the same IO transitions through different life stages, and across space, as different IOs with similar designs experience varying vitality. Recognizing this complexity illuminates the practice and performance of international cooperation.²³ Rather than expecting one moment of vitality to be a referendum on

²³ On the former, see Adler and Pouliot (2011); Pouliot (2015); on the latter, Gutner and Thompson (2010); Lall (2018).

an IO for all time, scholarship can instead focus both on the potential for IO resilience in the face of crisis or, conversely, whether a period of IO strength can create unintended consequences.

This special issue aims to provide scholars and policymakers with a grounded, empirically contextualized view of the current challenges facing international cooperation. The research framework of IO life cycles contextualizes both positive and negative fluctuations in IO vitality within organizations and across the broader system, helping us distinguish between changes leading toward decline, mission creep, and pathology, versus those that signal efficiency. This framework for studying international cooperation considers historical realities, selection, and normative biases, and the unintended consequences of IO formation. A life cycles perspective suggests that our current crisis in international governance is not only recognizable, but also surmountable.

Acknowledgements Many thanks to the authors of the special issue, as well as Axel Dreher, Raymond Hicks, Daniela Donno, Jeff Kucik, Dorothy Kronick, and Rachel Potter for valuable feedback on this introduction.

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